

2. Why focus on Onondaga Lake?

The Onondaga Nation has a responsibility to care for all relatives, including the earth, waters, and all beings. This is not ownership but a relationship of reciprocal care. Onondaga Lake is deeply significant, as the birthplace of the Haudenosaunee Confederacy, (which includes the Mohawk, Oneida, Onondaga, Cayuga, Seneca, and Tuscarora Nations). This is where the Great Law of Peace was introduced, the basis of the Haudenosaunee Confederacy system of government. This is the world's oldest continuous democratic system.

3. Why Maple Bay?

Located on the northwest shore, Maple Bay is one of the least polluted areas of the lake. It is a quiet, relatively secluded spot with many plants and animals. As a protected and secluded part of the lake, it provides some privacy for Onondaga people who will gather there.

4. How does land return help clean up?

This land return will allow the original caretakers of Onondaga Lake to have a voice in the decision-making around the lake. The Onondaga Nation serves as a representative in discussions on the cleanup of the natural world and all living beings, especially as plants and animals are being ignored. The need for ongoing cleanup is disregarded, and instead, deeply unpopular projects such as the county-built aquarium on inlet to the Lake are prioritized.



Facts About the LakeBack Campaign to Return Maple Bay to the Onondaga Nation



1. What's the goal of the LakeBack campaign?

LakeBack is a campaign to ensure that Maple Bay, on the shores of Onondaga Lake, is returned to the Onondaga Nation. The Onondaga County Legislature passed a resolution to return a piece of land on the shores of Onondaga Lake in a 2016 resolution, which replaced a previous County Legislature resolution from 2011 which also committed to a land return.

Lake Back will restore the relationship between the Onondaga Nation and sacred Onondaga Lake.

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5. What will this land be used for when it is returned to the Onondaga Nation?

The Onondaga Nation intends to hold ceremonies and social gatherings at Maple Bay. Ceremonies returning to the shores of Onondaga Lake, the birthplace of the Haudenosaunee Confederacy, are very significant and also an important part of healing Onondaga Lake. There is no intention to create commercial developments on the Lake as suggested in some circulating rumors.

6. Why aren't Indigenous lands taxed?

This area has been Onondaga land for thousands of years, and continues to be Onondaga land. Most of Onondaga County, including the city of Syracuse, sits within the Onondaga Nation territory recognized in the 1794 Treaty of Canandaigua. Therefore, the Nation does not have to pay taxes on lands it is reacquiring.

There was no mention of taxes in the original resolution from the County Legislature in 2011 and 2016. The current Onondaga County Executive, Ryan McMahon, was the chair of the County Legislature at that time and voted in favor of the land return resolution. Yet now taxes are being raised as a tactic to prevent the land return.

7. Why return Indigenous lands to Indigenous hands?

According to the U.S. Constitution, Article VI, treaties are the supreme law of the land. Honoring treaties is honoring the Constitution and being a good neighbor to Indigenous Nations. Indigenous Peoples are the original caretakers and recognized protectors of these lands under the treaties. We can all appreciate how traditional ecological knowledge can help us better understand how to clean up and care for the lake.

8. I thought there was a treaty about the lake? Isn't the lake covered by the treaty?

Yes, the 1794 Treaty of Canandaigua is still in effect, and the county is in violation of it. According to the treaty, the lake and the land around it belong to the Onondaga Nation. In light of this major treaty violation, a small portion of the lake returned is the least the county can do.

9. What are some good examples of Land Back?

There are many examples of land being returned to Indigenous Nations that are happening all around Turtle Island [the 'United States' and 'Canada'] but perhaps the most exciting one in our area is the return of over 1,000 acres of land to Onondaga Nation which took place in October 2024.

10. How can I learn more or get involved?

WWW.LAKEBACK.ORG

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RETURN MAPLE BAY
INDIGENOUS LANDS IN INDIGENOUS HANDS
#LAKEBACK